An' Push da Wind Down

By Lisa Harper

NELLIE: N-E-L-L-I-E? *(MOMMA thinks she hears something move.)*

MOMMA: Spells it free. Nellie be yo name. N-E-L-L-I-E.

NELLIE: N-E-L-L-I-E.

MOMMA: Da's it. See now, up nawth all da negras say it like dat. Dey say *(Stately.)* "Haudy sah, rna name be Nellie."

NELLIE: Dey say it like dat? ... Don't dey get wupped none with all dat *(Mimicing MOMMA.)* "Nellie" in 'em?

MOMMA: Cain't nobody gib ya da wuppin' up dere. Up dere ya got respect. An' don' be forgetin', don' neva look down at da groun'. Always put ya nose to da air. An' look dem dead in de eye. *(MOMMA thinks she hears something move.) (Scared.)* Sh- *(Urgently.)* We come too long a way ta be turnin' back now. Lawd Jesus, swing yo chariot low. Carrie us home lawd. *(Beat.) (The sound of Barking Dogs fades in.) (Panic stricken.)* No! come on, Nellie! We gotta run!

(MOMMA runs around a tree, dragging NELLIE behind her. MOMMA immediately breaks her ankle on an imaginary rock. She lets out a horrified scream. MOMMA tries to get up, but can't. She grabs her ankle. MOMMA pulls a tied roll of red cloth napkins from her apron pocket.) Nellie, heah! *(MOMMA hands NELLIE the napkins.)*

NELLIE: NO! What dis?! Come on Momma! Run!

MOMMA: *(Commanding.)* Dey my words to ya. When yousabe done wit readin' dese words, you free ... Dey's personal, Nellie. Don' nevah let nobody read 'em but chu. Run, Nellie! It best dey snatch me!

NELLIE: *(Crying.)* Momma!

(NELLIE looks at MOMMA stunned. Finally, she runs off crazily as Dogs Barking crescendos into blackout. MOMMA lets out a horrified scream. Silence.)

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INTRODUCTION

Set in rural Georgia from 1828 to 1838, An' Push da Wind Down follows a runaway slave as she heads north in search of freedom. Nellie, who cannot read, carries one thing: a roll of cloth napkins with letters written on them by her dead mother. On her way, she befriends Cherokee children and finds friendship, family, education and freedom in their village. Nellie and the Cherokees find strength in each other as the government threatens the Indians' liberty. The key to their freedom is ultimately found in the writing on the napkins. An' Push da Wind Down by Lisa Harper

(Lights up on outside of Barrett cabin. HIRAM, a Cherokee man, notices another presence. He stands still and looks straight out over audience. He addresses the man as if he were in audience. HIRAM does not look him in the eye. He looks past him.)

HIRAM: Ah. Howdy sah. Yessah ... The name's Hiram, Hiram Barrett... This here's my land. I was just... choppin' my wood- Huh? No, sah. Haven't seen a nigger like that round these parts. I'll be certain to look out for her ... Ah, sir? You ... know you're not supposed to come this far into the woods, this here's Cherokee territory ... Good day to ya! Ain't seen no niggers today. *(Silence)* They're comin' closer, Harriet -- the catchers. Soon they'll want the land you're standing on. *(NELLIE appears peeking from behind cabin.)* You the nigger the catcher was lookin' for?

NELLIE: No, sah.

HARRIET: She looks strong, Hiram.

HIRAM: She brings danger here, Harriet. They're looking for her. Where'd you run from?

NELLIE: Be runnin' nawth from da Fortune plantation in abouts South Carolina.

HARRIET: Girl, you turned west. This is Georgia.

NELLIE: Truly?

HARRIET: Hiram, she will die in these woods. *(NELLIE rocks and shakes her head. Lights fade except on NELLIE. All but NELLIE exit.)* Nellie, I need help weaving. I will pay you. It will not be much, but you will at least have a place to stay. It is

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safer here than it is out in those woods.

NELLIE: Can you read Missy Harriet? My momma could. She could write too.

HARRIET: I can't read or write the white man's talk, only the Cherokee. Mr. Barrett, on the other hand, knows their way just fine.

NELLIE: You do, Mr. Barrett? You can help me ta read. See? I got dese heahn.

(HIRAM snatches the napkins. NELLIE stands paralyzed at first, then rocks herself as HIRAM speaks.)

HIRAM: Nellie, you reading is all the excuse they'll need to hang every one of us. They want us off this land. Little boy down the river just found gold. No excuses, Nellie. I won't give 'em even one. If you stay to help Mrs. Barrett, then you are to abide by the same laws here as you would outside these woods. You are forbidden to read. Is that clear? If you are gonna be with us you will learn the Cherokee ways and you will be Cherokee. No niggahs are living in my house.

NELLIE: You got some will callin' me a niggah. I ain't yo *slave.*

HIRAM: You may not be my slave but I'll take the whip to ya just as quick.

NELLIE: *(Quiet, intense.)* You take dat whip ta me an' I eucha so deep- You won' know wheah you en' and I begin.

HARRIET: *(HARRIET crosses to HIRAM and gently snatches napkins from him. She crosses to NELLIE and gives them to her, keeping her back to HIRAM.)* You will not be whipped, ever. You are my helper, not my slave.

(Silence ...) NELLIE tries to put napkins in order. She stares at the napkins in silence till she breaks down and cries. Sound of MOMMA humming "Wade" fades in. NELLIE is held still by the music.)

NELLIE: Momma? Dat you? *(Realizing the sound is only a memory, NELLIE rocks herself. She continues, pulling herself together.)* I found some friends, Momma. Mightabe family ... 'ceptin' Mr. Barrett. I been thinkin' ... I be safe right

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here.... I ain't goin' nawth ... I be safe right heahn.

TRANSITION

Nellie lives with the Barretts for many years, learning to read in secret so that someday she'll be able to read the words Momma left her on the napkins.

MOMMA: *(Commanding.)* Dey my words to ya. When yousabe done wit readin' dese words, you free ... Dey's personal, Nellie. Don' nevah let nobody read 'em but chu.

NELLIE hums "Wade In The Water". NELLIE feels her MOMMA's presence and stops singing. NELLIE speaks out to audience as if she can see MOMMA out there.)

NELLIE: *(Looking around.)* I feel you ... I know you're here ... I can just about smell your spirit floatin' round me *(Looking straight out and seeing MOMMA.)* Oh ... I've been looking for you in my dreams. Where've you been all these years, Momma? ... *(Whispering.)* I can't remember your face ... *(HIRAM enters – controlled anger)*

HIRAM: *(Beat.)* I go to town, today, to buy a new chisel. I hear the whispers. Hear them calling me *red face*, calling me nigger. I do nothing. I walk down the street.I feel the spit as I step into it. Then another glop lands on my cheek. I want to break something. Tear something. *(Beat.)* They made our cousins, the Chochtaw, walk a thousand miles, Nellie. They walked and died. They say the Creek are next. How much longer, Nellie, until we die? I want to be treated like a man. I grew up on this land with them. I am like them.

NELLIE: No you're not! You're Hiram Barrett. Hiram, Injun, *poor,* Barrett.

HIRAM: [My friend], Ole' Lawrence . . . since you came, he turns his back to me. Today, I walk past [him] in that feed store talkin' to that yellow haired lady and smilin' at her and her smilin' at him. I want to yell into his face. I am

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family! See me!! Hear me!! He will not hear me because I am no longer Cherokee. To him I'm just a nigger ... *(Hiram exits)*

NELLIE: *(Beat.)* I'll leave tonight. *(she takes her Momma's napkins from her pocket crosses to the tree. She unties the roll and ceremoniously lays the napkins out.)* Where is north, Momma? ... Which way? "summah eighteen twenty four. dear nellie, ... i come up with da notion to writchu dis heahn *letta*"— *(NELLIE stops reading frozen in fear. She slowly looks up and sees same imaginary man in audience that HIRAM saw earlier. She looks down as she speaks.)* huh? ... naw, sah, I ain't no niggab run way ... na, got ma pass ... I... I... I be huh? ... come closab? ... *(She does.)* closab? *(NELLIE moves closer. Now she is dangerously close. She continues timidly, cautiously.)* Ya horse sho' do smell fine, sab ...

(NELLIE slowly raises her head with her eyes down till her face is almost facing the sky. She turns her head to the right as if commanded to. Then to the left. Then NELLIE turns around in a slow circle. Enter HIRAM.)

HIRAM: *(Looking past him.)* She's mine. I bought her in Charlestown ... last week ... I have the papers, at home ... what's what? *(HIRAM looks down to NELLIE's hand holding the napkins.)* Oh! Just some old rags we sent with the niggah to bring to Ole' Lawrence over yonder past the cotton patch ... He's in need of some rags, sah ... *(To NELLIE.)* Sarah ... Sarah?

NELLIE: Oh! Yessa, Massa.

HIRAM: You should know by now, the cotton patch is on the *north* side of the cabin. *(To man, confiding.)* You know these niggers ... gotta tell 'em things three and four *times*- *(To NELLIE, pointing.)* The *north* side, Sarah! The *north* side! *(To man, confiding.)* Dumb as a deer ... Sorry to cause you so much trouble. I will keep my eye out for the runaway. HIRAM. Good day, sah. *(HIRAM watches him go. NELLIE remains frozen.)* You can relax now ... He's gone. *(Silence.)*

NELLIE: Thank you ...

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HIRAM: He saw you reading.

NELLIE: I don't know. I'mj ust so glad . . .

HIRAM: Put them in my hands, Nellie. Put them in my hands. Now. *(HIRAM reaches for the napkins.)*

NELLIE: No! Massa Barrett! No! Give me another chance. I promise I'll run tonight. NO! DON'T TAKE MY MOMMA FROM ME AGAIN! You hear me!? *(HIRAM takes the napkins from Nellie's hands by force)*

HIRAM: You may stay, Nellie. Mrs. Barrett wants you ... and I cannot hurt her. If you speak of these napkins even once that will be the day you leave ... without them. They are watching us now. You will not endanger my family again. *(Hiram exits)*

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NELLIE: Eli taught me [to read[, Momma. Mr. Barrett, he gets the newspaper one time every moon. I comb it from back to front. I look for news about you. Course, I know white men ain't gonna take no intrest in a niggah lady swingin' from a tree. But I comb it just the same. *(Beat.)* Mr. Barrett has the napkins. *(Beat.)* I miss you ... you say ... "Read dem napkins, Nellie. Den you be free ... some parts of you is free, like yo' hands and yo' foots. You move dem wheresoevah ya wants dem ta go. But yo spirit still bound. Dem napkins gonna' free yone spirit." *(Beat.*) Momma? Do you think freedom is flying? What happens if you fall from freedom? Can your wings break? *(Beat, slowly, determined.)* I'm gonna read, Momma. Read what you gave me. I know you're with me, Momma ...

HIRAM: *(who has been listening – he enters hesitantly, then speaks)* Look at the water, Nellie, how free it is. It glides along and dances around rocks and slips through the fingers of those who would want to control it. I want to be like that water. I don't want to be like the Choctaws who were forced to walk in bloody snow. I want to slip through the soldiers' grasp and live on this land

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forever. The long walk is coming ... *(HIRAM takes the napkins andhands them to NELLIE.)* Here ... *(5 second pause.)* ... Be free ... *(Whispering.)* Forgive me.

NELLIE: The last time I saw my momma she was huddled in a pile of leaves with blood drippin' from her head and feet. She was yelling ... I crossed a crick and hid under a pile a leaves. When I get my guts up ta look out I see them dogs tearin' at her flesh and my momma's not movin' ... they chewed my Momma ... Then the men beat her with a Sassafras branch they found near by. Those dogs licked the new blood holes in her back ... She cried ... lain' nevah see my Momma cry before that day.

HIRAM: Life is a trail of tears, Nellie. Loss ... walks close, our greatest enemy ... while grief... holds our hands ... our best friend. Listen, Nellie ... *(NELLIE stares at him.)* I'm sorry. *(Hiram exits)*

NELLIE: *(To the napkins.)* Whatchyou got ta say ta me, Momma? *(NELLIE unwraps the napkins. She kisses them, and reads.)* "summah, eighteen hundred and twenty four"-I was just six when she wrote this!-"dear Nellie, I come up wit da notion ta writchu dis heahn lettah 'cause anti sissy's baby milly jus' done been sold 'way. my mind go back ta ya. i's writin' dis heahn lettah so's you might knows i loves ya. yo' pappy jus' lef', he went on back up to da big house. is dere he belong. not wit me, ... not wit you ... We called him "massa" ... he was yo' fathah." *(To herself)* No ... no ... *(Momma takes over her story)*

MOMMA: *(Whispering.)* Nellie, i gone tells ya a story, gone gib ya power such dat no thang is dis heahn worl' can evah touch ya soul. dey tells me, say way back in africa be peoples could fly. say dey lift dey hands up an' sail on da back o' da wind. one day say da peoples wings be bound up by ones come from da sea. dey be force ta come ta a new land. cain' fly no mo'. masters make 'em trade dey wings fa hoes. say dey mix in with da othah africans an no body could tells 'em apart. say overseer break one bone in every african's body till

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finally dey needs de hoes jus' ta keep 'em standin'. dey work night and day. oversser cry out to da africans say ... 'faster ya black pigs! Move dat cotton, niggah!" den he wup em harder. no body can remember the magic words what made dem able ta fly back home in africa. so dey walk da rows a cotton. no body but one african calls hisself Abraham. say one day when da overseer whip be lickin' at da african foots an' da sun be burnin' down on de backs an' da bones be a breakiri', say one gal calls hersef Lydia cry out to ole' Abraham say "now, befoe anothah life be crushed! speak da words!' ole' Abraham runned over an take hold a Lydia's bloody hands an raise his arms ... KUM YALI KUM BUBA TAMBE!

NELLIE: *(NELLIE places napkin on ground in front of her and lifts her arms as if to fly.) (whispering.)* Kum Yali Kum Buba Tambe ...

MOMMA: den all aroun' him da words be whispered. say one by one da peoples stood straight, drop dey hoes in da field, lift dey arms up and push da wind down neaf 'em. till dey all feel dat african spirit rollin' tru dey arms. and dey rise up free as birds in a african sky. and dey fly far away to freedom. ... Look at me, Nellie. I be here. Kum Yali, Kum Buba Tambe, Nellie. It be where you come from. When you fly, Nellie, cain' no body touch ya spirit. Dey can put shackles on y!l foots and yokes 'round yo' neck, but when ya knows how ta fly, dey cain' nevah touch yone spirit. do ya have ears ta hear what I be speakin' to ya, Nellie? Fly nawth and spell yo' name free.

NELLIE. *(Beat... gravely.)* My name is Nellie Lawrence. N-E-L-L-I-E. *(Beat.) KUM YALI, KUM BUBA TAMBE!! (NELLIE breathes in deep and brings her arms down as if pushing the wind down. Whispering.)* dey tell me ... way back in africa ... peoples could fly. say dey lift dey arms ... an' push da wind down low beneaf 'em ... and dey jus' rise up free as birds. an dey fly far away to freedom ... Gonna be free now ... gonna walk free ... somehow. *(Silence. Fade to Black)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lisa Harper
ISBN: 978-0573696657
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 1998

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
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